

OPERATIONAL DOCUMENT — CONFIDENTIAL

The Final Steps Accord v3.1

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	COMPANION	Negotiator's Brief
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A field-ready operational guide for the final hours of mediation. Exact citations, dual-narrative frames, and durability architecture — designed to get this document signed before the window closes.

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SECTION 1

Sticking Point Navigation

The three deal-breakers that collapsed every previous negotiation — and the exact page where each is solved in v3.1.

1.1 The Hormuz Compromise — JHTA + PGSA Integration

PRIMARY CITATION

Article 4 (pp. 10–16) — JHTA establishment, PGSA sovereignty recalibration, dual-branding transit permits
Addendum A-2 (pp. 51–57) — Modular Maritime Governance Preamble: JHTA/PGSA operate under distinct, non-conflicting mandates within the modular architecture

The Deadlock: Iran established the PGSA on 5 May 2026 as the sole Hormuz authority, requiring vessels to submit 40+ data items and pay fees up to \$2 million. The US explicitly rejected any tolling: *"We don't want tolls. It's an international waterway."* The IRGC considers Hormuz control a core strategic deterrent. Previous frameworks failed because they demanded one side surrender its position entirely.

The v3.1 Solution (Optical Compromise):

ELEMENT	WHAT IRAN GETS	WHAT THE US GETS
JHTA Mandate	PGSA recognized as sole coastal enforcement in Iranian territorial waters	JHTA governs the international transit corridor under UNCLOS; no Iranian tolling on international traffic
Permit System	PGSA portal processes applications; dual-branded permits	JHTA verifies against IMO/Lloyd's List/INTERPOL databases; fees routed through neutral MMMF, not to Iran
Revenue	40% of MMMF revenue to Iranian Civilian Reconstruction Fund	Fees are transparent multilateral maintenance payments, not unilateral tolls
Modularity Shield	<i>"Maritime coordination under this Article operates independently of localized friction in external operational theaters"</i> — Addendum A-2, Article 4 Preamble	

Immediate Talking Point: *"The Strait is open to international navigation under multilateral governance — not Iranian unilateral control. The PGSA's role is limited to coastal enforcement; the transit corridor is governed by UNCLOS."* (Article 4.3, p. 12)

1.2 The Nuclear Stockpile — HEU Custody + Day 45 Default Pathway

PRIMARY CITATION

Article 1 (pp. 6–8) — IAEA Dual-Lock Custody Exchange; legal title (CBI) decoupled from physical custody
Article 1.5 (p. 8) — Six Pathways for Final Disposition (Phase 2, Days 30–60)
Addendum A-1 (pp. 41–50) — Article 2.4: Automatic Default Pathway (Day 45 Nuclear Deadlock Breaker)

The Deadlock: Rubio demanded physical removal of Iran's ~400 kg HEU stockpile. Iran has communicated, as a binding sovereign position through its authorized negotiating delegation, that its enriched uranium must remain

under Iranian legal title and within Iranian territory during the Phase 1 verification period. This chasm collapsed every previous negotiation.

The v3.1 Solution (Two-Layer Architecture):

PHASE	TIMELINE	IRANIAN COMMITMENT	US RECIPROCAL
Phase 1 Baseline Verification	Days 1–30	Physical consolidation, inventory, IAEA custody (Pathway A or B); CBI retains sovereign legal title	\$250M humanitarian tranche; OFAC general license; 5th Fleet stand-off posture
Phase 2 Nuclear Window	Days 30–60	Select disposition pathway from six-pathway menu; no US veto over selection	Tranche 2 asset release (25%); petrochemical export licenses

THE DEADLOCK BREAKER — ADDENDUM A-1, ARTICLE 2.4.3

If the Parties fail to agree on a final HEU disposition pathway by Day 45, **Pathway A** (in-country downblending to medical-grade LEU at Esfahan) becomes the automatic default. IAEA verifies commencement within 7 days. **Neither Party's failure to agree is a material breach.** The deal survives. The ceasefire holds.

Immediate Talking Point: *"The entire stockpile of near-weapons-grade material has been placed under IAEA custody with US monitoring access. Breakout time extended from weeks to over a year."* (Article 1, US Narrative Frame, p. 7)

1.3 The Lebanon Front — Dossier Isolation Firewall

PRIMARY CITATION

- Appendix E (pp. 35–40) — Lebanon and Levant Front Stabilization Protocol (v3.0)
- Article E.2 (p. 36–37) — Dossier Isolation Firewall (Operative and Binding)
- Article 11.3 (p. 21) — Attribution Deferral Window for Proxy Incidents

The Deadlock: Iran demands an end to the war on *all* fronts, including Lebanon. The US/Israel want Lebanon kept separate. If Hezbollah fires rockets while the nuclear deal is being signed, hardliners on both sides demand collapse.

The v3.1 Solution (Three-Layer Firewall):

LAYER	MECHANISM	EFFECT
Proxy Operational Pause	Hezbollah de-escalation protocol with phased operational parameters (Days 1–180)	Immediate security benefit to Israel; Iran can say the war ends on all fronts
Dossier Isolation Firewall	Legally prohibits Lebanon incidents from triggering stepback on the core US-Iran Accord	What happens in Lebanon stays in Lebanon — it cannot blow back onto Hormuz

Levant	Parallel diplomatic track with independent timeline	Addresses Iran's allies without requiring
Regional	(Steering Committee: Lebanon, Israel, US; Iran as	Iran to sit at the same table as Israel
Basket	observer)	

ESCALATION CEILING — APPENDIX E.2.2

Even if the Levant situation deteriorates significantly (major Israeli ground operation, large-scale Hezbollah rocket campaign, civilian mass casualty event), the Firewall remains in force. The Core Accord can only be affected if: **(a)** the UN Security Council determines a grave breach of IHL **and (b)** the JIG unanimously determines the breach is directly linked to a core Accord commitment violation. This dual threshold is designed to be virtually impossible to meet.

SECTION 2

Dual-Narrative Verification

The exact legal mechanisms proving why both Washington and Tehran can declare victory simultaneously. If either capital asks "what did we win?" — point them here.

2.1 Washington's Victory Frame

UNITED STATES — WHAT WE WON		
ISSUE	CLAIM	LEGAL ANCHOR
Nuclear	Iran's 60% enrichment halted and placed under permanent IAEA lock. HEU neutralized with immediate physical custody. Breakout time: weeks to over a year.	Article 1; Verification Timeline (p. 8)
Maritime	No more unilateral Iranian tolling. Strait governed under multilateral UNCLOS authority. US holds permanent council seat.	Article 4.1–4.2; JHTA Charter (pp. 10–12)
Economic	No reparations paid. Sanctions relief conditional, reversible, tied to verified compliance. Leverage architecture intact.	Article 7 (Tranche Architecture, p. 17); Article 8 (Escrow, p. 18)
Security	Iran's missile and drone transfers to proxies frozen. Regional threat environment stabilized.	Article 14 (Three-Pillar Pause, p. 23)
Lebanon	Core agreement addresses nuclear proliferation and freedom of navigation. Lebanon is a separate file with full Israeli participation.	Appendix E; Dossier Isolation Firewall (p. 36)

2.2 Tehran's Victory Frame

ISLAMIC REPUBLIC OF IRAN — WHAT WE WON		
ISSUE	CLAIM	LEGAL ANCHOR
Nuclear	Legal title to HEU remains with Central Bank of Iran — sovereign property, not surrendered. NPT rights affirmed. Enrichment continues at 3.67% under IAEA safeguards.	Article 1.1 (Legal Title Structure, p. 7); Article 2.1 (Moratorium, p. 8)
Maritime	PGSA recognized as sole executive coastal law enforcement in Iranian territorial waters. Iran holds permanent co-chair seat with veto rights. IRGC authority explicitly preserved.	Article 4.2-B (p. 11); Article 4.4 (Governing Council, p. 12)
Economic	Frozen assets released through neutral escrow, not surrendered. SWIFT reconnection restores Iran's place in the global economy.	Article 8 (Escrow, p. 18); Article 9 (SWIFT Protocol, p. 19)
Sovereignty	No facility destroyed. Fordow converted into global medical center — triumph of Iranian science. Missile and drone programs remain sovereign and intact.	Article 3 (Mothball Protocol, p. 9); Article 14.2 (Safeguards, p. 24)
Lebanon	Framework ends the war on all fronts. Through Levant Regional Basket, Iran ensures allies in Lebanon are not abandoned.	Appendix E.1 (Proxy Pause, p. 35); Appendix E.3 (Regional Basket, p. 37)

2.3 The Legal Mechanisms Enabling Both Narratives

Both victory frames are not spin — they are **legally grounded in the operative text**. The architecture that makes this possible:

MECHANISM	HOW IT WORKS	CITATION
Optical Compromise	Both statements are factually accurate under the Charter. The JHTA governs international transit; the PGSA governs Iranian coastal waters. Neither encroaches on the other.	Article 4.3 (p. 12)
Title/Custody Decoupling	CBI retains sovereign legal title (Iran's win). IAEA holds physical custody with US monitoring access (US win). Same clause, both claims valid.	Article 1.1 (p. 7)
Narrative Protection Clause	Both Parties may characterize the default pathway consistent with domestic requirements — US as "secure verified downblending," Iran as "sovereign in-country conversion."	Addendum A-1, 2.4.5(d) (p. 44)
Pre-Cleared Talking Points	Both capitals issue talking points confirming the Lebanon file is managed through separate mechanisms. No official may publicly link Hormuz to Lebanon without triggering penalties.	Appendix E.2.1 (p. 37)

SECTION 3

System Durability

How the timeline anchors and firewall architecture protect the deal from immediate collapse — even if the first crisis hits within 72 hours.

3.1 Timeline Anchors (The 180-Day Implementation Roadmap)

PRIMARY CITATION

Part V (pp. 25–29) — The 180-Day Implementation Roadmap with phased milestones
Article 11 (pp. 21–22) — Binding Letter of Intent with Auto-Renewing Ceasefire

The timeline is designed so that **every milestone is irreversible once executed** and every phase builds on the previous one:

PHASE	DAYS	IRREVERSIBLE ANCHOR	VERIFICATION
Foundation	1–14	HEU dual-lock custody activated; IAEA inventory complete; naval stand-off positions established	IAEA custody verification certificate (Day 4); dual-lock seals applied
Consolidation	15–44	Rotor removal complete; mothball protocol initiated; Black-Box telemetry installed	IAEA serial-numbered rotor inventory; encrypted data feed confirmed
Normalization	45–120	Civilian transition enrichment at 3.67% ceiling; SWIFT Phase 2 active; JHTA fully operational	OLEM confirms enrichment ceiling; SWIFT confirms bank connections
Sustainability	121–180	Fordow Joint Venture operational; full 180-day compliance certified; successor framework negotiations convened	TCC revenue distribution reports; IAEA + JIG joint certification

THE CEASEFIRE ARCHITECTURE — ARTICLE 11.2

The ceasefire is a **self-renewing 72-hour module**. If verification teams report compliance at Hour 71, the module auto-renews for another 72 hours. Peace is maintained without either side signing away long-term leverage upfront. The ceasefire clock (72-hour loops) and the implementation clock (30-day phases) are **separate** — neutralizing the "negotiation about negotiation" trap.

3.2 The Appendix E Firewall

PRIMARY CITATION

Appendix E.2 (pp. 36–37) — Dossier Isolation Firewall (Operative and Binding)
Appendix E.1 (pp. 35–36) — Proxy Operational Pause: Hezbollah De-escalation Protocol

The Firewall operates at **three independent levels**:

LEVEL	MECHANISM	PRACTICAL EFFECT
Legal	Exchange of Letters explicitly excludes "incidents in the Levant theater involving non-state actors" from the stepback trigger definition in Article 13	A Hezbollah rocket strike is legally excluded from triggering Accord suspension
Technical	Swiss Dashboard maintains separate tracks for "Core Accord Compliance" and "Regional Security Incidents." Stepback algorithms reference only Core Compliance.	Even if a Lebanon incident is logged, it cannot trigger automated stepback
Political	Both capitals issue pre-cleared talking points confirming Lebanon is a separate file. No official may publicly link Hormuz to Lebanon without narrative violation penalties.	Political pressure to collapse the deal over Lebanon incidents is preemptively neutralized

3.3 Collapse Protection Architecture

PRIMARY CITATIONS

Article 13 (pp. 22–23) — Three-Tier Breach System with Step-Back Architecture

Addendum A-2 (pp. 51–57) — Modular Maritime Governance Preamble

Part V — Framework Survival Core (p. 28)

Even in the worst-case scenario, the Accord does not collapse catastrophically. It **degrades in graduated tiers**:

FAILURE MODE	RESPONSE	WHAT SURVIVES
Tier 1: Technical dispute (<0.5% above enrichment ceiling; ≤2 un-mothballed rotors)	14-day engineering resolution; no rollback; confidential handling	Everything
Tier 2: Material disruption (>0.5% above ceiling; >2 rotors; >72h IAEA obstruction)	25% benefit reduction; 30-day remediation; full restore on clean certification	Humanitarian tranches; ceasefire; Survival Core
Tier 3: Deliberate hostile violation (nuclear weapons activity; fissile diversion; IAEA attack)	50% reduction; 90-day remediation; full earn-back after sustained compliance	Humanitarian corridor; diplomatic channel; Survival Core (180 days)
Full suspension	Reconstitution Conference within 30 days (Pakistan/UN-convened)	Ceasefire hotline; humanitarian access; emergency diplomatic channel

THE THREE IMMUTABLE PRINCIPLES

- 1. Telemetry-First Diplomacy:** Every commitment must be expressible as a sensor reading, data feed, or physical lock confirmation.
- 2. Rollback, Not Snapback:** If either party breaches, the Framework does not collapse. It pauses in graduated tiers.
- 3. Modular Architecture:** Failure in one module does not cascade. Maritime disputes cannot terminate humanitarian channels. Nuclear verification gaps do not affect Hormuz transit. Lebanon incidents cannot collapse the core US-Iran agreement.

QUICK REFERENCE

Final Hour Checklist

IF THEY SAY...	YOU SAY...	TURN TO PAGE
"Iran keeps the uranium on its soil — that's unacceptable."	"Physical custody is with the IAEA. CBI retains legal title only. Breakout time goes from weeks to over a year."	6–8
"The PGSA is just Iranian tolling by another name."	"PGSA only operates in Iranian territorial waters. All commercial safety fees are routed through the neutral MMMF in Oman to prevent unilateral tolling. Resource disbursements are strictly managed by the neutral chair for regional maritime upkeep and safety performance metrics."	10–12
"If Hezbollah attacks, the whole deal collapses."	"The Dossier Isolation Firewall legally prevents Lebanon incidents from triggering stepback. Three independent levels: legal, technical, and political."	36–37
"What happens if we can't agree on a disposition pathway?"	"Day 45 automatic default: Pathway A, in-country downblending to medical-grade LEU at Esfahan. IAEA verifies within 7 days. Not a breach."	41–44
"This is an all-or-nothing treaty."	"The framework is strictly modular. Maritime coordination operates independently of friction in external theaters. Collapse in one basket does not cascade."	51–53
"How can both sides claim victory?"	"Because both claims are factually accurate under the operative text. Every provision is designed as an optical compromise — both narratives are legally grounded."	pp. 7, 12, 44 (Narrative Protection Clauses)

"This document represents the culmination of forty drafts, two wars, and decades of enmity. It is not perfect. It is not permanent. It is possible. And possibility, in this moment, is everything."